

RAMbling Memory

Agent 001 goes shopping in the volatile RAM market

The monsoon brings joy to all, and I'm no exception—I love walking in the rain and pretending to not have a care in the world. Unfortunately, it's a bad time of the year for our little white computing boxes. Sure the climate makes them run cooler, but the humidity can sometimes stop them cold—condensation can blow up components at times.

This weekend I was out on a stroll, enjoying myself while the rain gods showered the earth. Happily soaked, I returned home and poured myself a cup of hot coffee, sat down and switched on my PC. To my dismay, all I saw was a blank screen and heard the dreaded death toll of my RAM. Immediately I switched off, opened the cabinet and realised that my decision to keep my PC near a window, so that I could enjoy the real and cyber world simultaneously, was a big mistake. Moisture is a PC component's biggest enemy, and alas my RAM

chip had suffered a fatal blow. After a few feeble attempts at digital CPR, involving a hair dryer and trying out different RAM slots, I declared my chip to be indisputably dead.

After a quick eulogy and dump-in-the-dustbin funeral, I headed out to buy myself a new RAM chip. Being the end of the month, I was on the lookout for the cheapest solution available. My first stop was the *nukkad-wallah* computer shop. When I asked for a 256 MB SD RAM chip, he handed me a Hynix module and told me the damage would be Rs 2,500. After a brief pause to catch my breath, I asked why SD RAM was so expensive. He informed me that SD RAM was soon to be extinct, and is now sold as antiques. Dealers are not stocking SD RAM, as the faster and now cheaper DDR RAM is taking over. I couldn't believe my ears, as I had bought my now deceased SD RAM for Rs 1,200 only a few months ago.

So, I decided to venture further away from home, and went RAM shopping in Lamington Road. The first dealer I came across, was selling the same Hynix module for Rs 2,300, but was quick to suggest that I buy DDR RAM instead. "*Aare bhayya*, when you can get double the performance at a cheaper price, *toh sochna kya*", he said. When I told him my motherboard didn't support DDR RAM, pat came the reply, "*Toh motherboard upgrade karo*".

My next stop was also fruitless, as the vendor told me he had stopped selling SD RAM a month ago—all he had was the different flavours of DDR RAM.

When I asked for prices, I was told that normal Hynix 256 MB DDR RAM was available for as low as Rs 1,700, the 333 MHz variety costs Rs 2,200, and the fastest 400 MHz version costs just Rs

2,800. Cursing my luck for buying a dinosaur, I moved on in my search for the elusive cheap RAM chip.

The next dealer had a new swanky, modern looking shop. He also sold only DDR RAM, but offered a choice of brands, such as Kingston, Cosair, Samsung, etc. Kingston is supposed to be really good, and also

more expensive. Kingston RAM costs Rs 1,950, Rs 2,350 and Rs 3,500 for 266 MHz, 333 MHz and 400 MHz respectively.

Onwards I went, looking for a solution to my problems. I was about to call it a day, and was resigned to buying a new DDR

RAM supporting motherboard, when I came across a very troubled looking vendor, who told me that he would get the RAM for me for Rs 1,800, but with only 6 months warranty. Immediately suspicious, I asked why that was so, and was told that he had a few pieces lying around which he had bought a few months ago for really cheap and was now just looking to get rid of them as no one was buying SD RAM anymore.

I wasn't too worried about the 6 months warranty, as I knew I would probably upgrade to a DDR-based motherboard way before then. So, after double checking the RAM, I headed off home, happy that I had got what I wanted, and cheap! ■

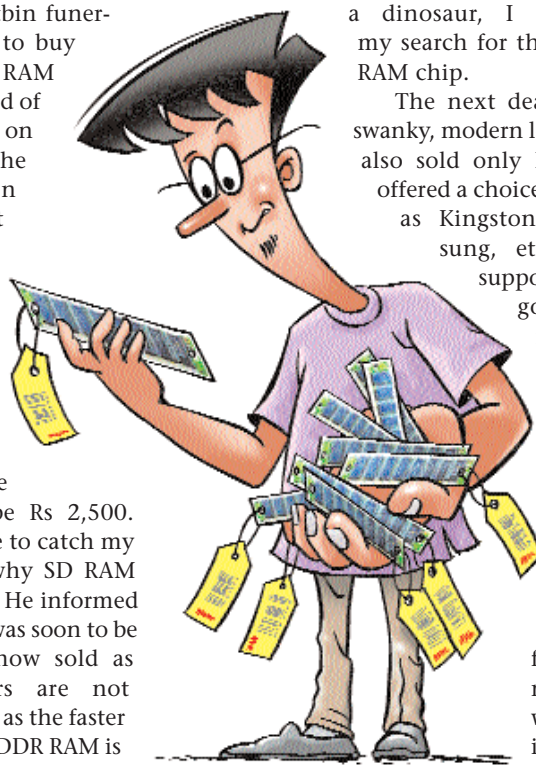


ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar



■ Never buy second hand RAM modules. Since they don't carry any warranty, you might end up wasting your money.

■ If you are buying a new PC, opt for a DDR RAM-based motherboard, as DDR is much faster, and cheaper as well.

■ Before buying a DDR 333 or a DDR 400 memory module, make sure it is compatible with your motherboard. This can be verified from the motherboard manufacturers Web site.

■ Insist on genuine RAM chips. Generally what we get in Indian market, are modules that are manufactured locally by soldering memory chips onto a cheap quality PCB.

■ Manufacturers such as Kingston, Corsair, Crucial, etc., offer a lifetime warranty (five years actually, a computer's lifetime not yours). Pay a little extra and opt for this warranty, to give you peace of mind.